The Hunter and the Fox

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - College/University, Pole Dancing, Oblivious Glimmer/Bow, Really Oblivious Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio, Partners to Lovers, Burlesque-ish Variete Show, POV Alternating

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by silveradept

Summary

Adora and Catra meet in Ms. Fizz's pole dance class, and both of them don't want to let their crushes out on someone who probably isn't interested, despite what their gossip-mainlining friends have to say about it. When Adora gets to see Kat perform on stage in a different context, they both start to believe it's possible that they're compatible. Assuming nobody does anything self-sabotaging along the way.

Notes

Created as a thank-you for a generous donation made during the Fandom Trumps Hate 2021 fundraising event.

Aptly SPAGinated by Cyan-tinted-lenses

See the end of the work for more notes

"All right, for the next few weeks, we're going to be concentrating on duo work," Ms. Fizz said. "Depending on who is at each class, I'm going to partner you up so you will have someone to work with. Individually, you can do quite a bit, but when you have more than one person to do things with, an entire new set of possibilities opens up for you."

The students' faces displayed the full spectrum of reactions between complete enthusiasm and immovable cynicism.

"For today, I've matched more experienced practitioners with less experienced ones, but I want you to be thinking about who you would be compatible with for a duo routine."

Adora ended up with a newcomer to the class. Or, at least someone she hasn't seen before. She was smaller than what Adora expected from new people to the class, but she also looked like she was here to do the work, rather than just for fun.

Most newcomers came in as a group, giggling about what they might do for their boyfriends or husbands, and left just as quickly after they realized how sore they were from the beginning lesson. Some were students looking for an all-around workout, and they usually stayed if they liked it, or they would be somewhere else in the gym, working on silks or with some of the other aerialist apparatuses. Every now and then, she'd see one of the gymnastics team show up, only to be chased away by public outcry about morals and decency and the corruption of youth. Wouldn't do to have rising young stars cavorting with *strippers*, even if nobody that Adora knew had ever admitted to working in a club. The possibility that there might be a sex worker among them was enough to bring out the clutched pearls when it came to student athletes.

Never mind that the gymnasts were the ones who could (and did) appreciate the routines being worked on the best when they stopped by.

"Hi, I'm Adora," she said, sticking her hand out to shake with her assigned partner.

"Kat," the other woman said, making no move to return the offered handshake. "What kind of parent names their child Adora?"

"The kind that are really fond of the cartoons they watched when they were children," Adora said.

"Ouch. Wow," Kat said, starting to stretch by resting her leg on the back of one of the nearby chairs. "Have you ever thought about changing it?"

"Too much hassle, unless I'm getting married," Adora said, mirroring Kat's stretch with a different chair. "Have you been to a class before?"

"I've been meaning to," Kat said, "but between classes and work, it's hard to carve out some time to learn new skills."

That was an interesting way of phrasing it, Adora thought as she transitioned into her arm and shoulder stretches, bracing herself against the pole to keep her arms straight. Kat mirrored her on the other side of the pole, looking relaxed as she stretched.

"Where do you work?" Adora asked, hoping not to sound like she was fishing.

"Eh, the kind of place where your tips depend on how much T&A you show off." Kat let herself bend backward as far as her grip would let her, while Adora stretched up and outward, trying to remember to keep her toes pointed and her lines crisp. When she finished, Kat was staring at her with a grin on her face.

"What, no 'No offense, but you don't seem the type of person who would work in that kind of place'?" she teased.

"Why would I say that?" Adora replied. "You find work where you can."

Thankfully, Ms. Fizz called all the students together before things could get any more awkward, demonstrating the swing on and off the pole that she wanted them to practice, before they started learning how to use the pole when there was someone else already on it. To Adora's surprise, Kat picked it up quickly and with what looked like good form to her.

"I thought you said you haven't done this before," Adora said while Kat spun.

"Not in a class setting," Kat replied, climbing up a bit for better height. "But, you know, there's tons of instructional videos to watch online and plenty of places to practice on the campus, if you know where to look."

That made sense, when Adora thought about it. Ms. Fizz wouldn't let someone who couldn't demonstrate they knew what they were doing into the more advanced classes. Turning Kat's other suggestion over in her head, Adora thought a bit about her own campus routes, but she couldn't picture any spots where it would be good to practice. Maybe Kat saw the world like those parkour guys Adora occasionally saw, turning flips and climbing things in ways that the public safety officers would have a fit about.

"So, we're both students," she said, swapping places with Kat on the pole and staring her own spins. "I wonder if we have any classes together."

"I don't care," Kat said immediately. Adora tried to hide the flash of disappointment, but she wasn't fast enough. "Look, I'm here to get a workout, not to tell my life story to someone I've just met, okay?" Kat continued.

Adora could respect that, even if it felt like Kat was slamming a door in her face—one she hadn't even known was there. It would make coming up with a good routine together more difficult, so Adora was probably going to have to partner with someone else. Which was too bad, really, because there was something about Kat that she liked.

Kat demonstrated her excellent agility by climbing up above Adora, inverting herself and then matching Adora's rotation, so they spent the entire spin starting each other in the face, giving Adora more than enough time to recognize both how talented and how cute Kat was. And also that she had eyes with different colored irises.

"I think we could work well together," Adora said when they had finished. "You sure this is your first time working with someone else?"

"On something like this, yeah," Kat said. "How did you get that leg hook to work? Every time I try to go one-handed like that, I fall."

"It's more of a knee hook than a leg hook," Adora said. "Once it's going, I can take one hand off and between the one hand, the one leg, and a little bit of hope, I should be able to keep spinning fast enough to look elegant and not crash."

"Can you show that to me again?" Kat asked.

"Maybe next time?" Adora said.

"Why wait?"

"Time to start your cool-downs, class," Ms. Fizz said. "Good work today. Keep thinking about who you might want as your partners."

Kat grumbled, but she didn't press Adora with Ms. Fizz right there.

"I think she's a student," Adora said as she and Glimmer slid into their seats at the back of the lecture theater. "If you see her, make sure she has heterochromia."

"Hetero-what?" Glimmer said.

"She has different-colored eyes," Adora said.

"Huh. I didn't know that was a thing," Glimmer replied. "This doesn't sound like professional curiosity. You don't usually scour the Internet for new words for someone you meet at pole class. How cute is she?"

"Super cute," Adora said. "She wasn't very interested in sharing all that much, though, so I didn't learn much about her."

"Ooo, what if 'Kat' is short for something that would put her in the Weird Names Club?" Glimmer said. While Adora's parents had made questionable choices about who to name their child after, the way Glimmer described it, her parents had decided that they would name their child after the song playing when Angela's water broke, and for better or worse, it had been one of Ziggy Stardust's. So Glimmer Starchild Avery was named, and until she'd gotten to university and discovered she wasn't the only person with a tale of woe and nostalgia about how she was named, she'd been extremely salty about it. As soon as she'd met Adora, she'd declared them both members of the Weird Names Club, and thus could never have their friendship separated.

"I doubt it. Kat seemed to be pretty normal."

"Except for her eyes."

"And that she was pretty good for someone who just joined the class, but Ms. Fizz wouldn't have let her in if she couldn't handle it."

The lecture began before they could discuss more about Kat, but a few minutes in, Glimmer opened a second window on her laptop and started typing a message for Adora.

Are you going to ask her out?

Adora kept typing her notes, ignoring Glimmer's question by exaggeratedly leaning in as if the lecture was the most important thing in the world. Glimmer frowned at Adora.

You kept telling me how much you wanted a strong woman who wasn't afraid of dating a strong woman. Kat seems like she fits your type pretty well.

Adora flicked her eyes over to Glimmer's chat, but continued to take notes rather than respond.

You really like her, then. Guess I'll just have to go down to the front row after class and ask her out for you.

Adora casually leaned back so she could give Glimmer a murderous look without attracting the attention of the lecturer. Glimmer made a small internal cheer of victory when Adora moved her cursor into the chat window and started typing back.

Don't do that. Wait, do you even know even know if she’s in this class? And she's probably straight, anyway. No reason to believe someone you like might like you back.

Glimmer glowered at Adora.

I thought we were all taking this dance class so we'd have really good skills to impress people with. So that we could get dates! You know that there are plenty of people that think being able to work a pole is hot, and that's after you screen out the ones that have to share a brain cell between head and crotch like the Fates passing the eye between them.

Adora rolled her eyes, finished a sentence and quickly put in her response.

That's the Graeae, they might be on the test next week, and stop trying to distract me.

Glimmer grumbled and went back to paying more attention to her own note taking, before succumbing to temptation and sending another message in chat.

You know that Bo is out there all the time talking about his pole skills.

Wait, that came out wrong.

Bo got that date just last week with the girl with the really long purple hair. I'm pretty sure he told her he was working on his pole dancing.

Adora gave Glimmer the long blink that would have been a great heaving sigh if she had been able to do it without making a scene in the auditorium.

I think she's more interested in Bo's laptop than his pole… (wait for it)…dancing. I overheard them talking specs for some sort of project she's interested in building. If I had been able to understand any of it, I probably would have thought it was cool.

Glimmer stifled a snort, and both of them paid careful attention to their note-taking in case they were getting any looks from the other students.

They're still a pretty cute match. Why can't we get anyone cute like that?

Adora ignored the message, not really wanting to think about her dating life (or lack thereof) while they were in a class about how much jealous and petty gods decided to fuck around with each other and humans because of matters of lust (and occasionally love).

Oh, I see. *I'm* the only one who's going to be moaning about not getting a date. *You're* going to go get your multi-colored eyes girl at class or something. You'll both be spinning and gazing lovingly into each other's eyes, and confess your love through dance or something like that.

Adora twitched next to Glimmer, but kept taking notes for a little while longer before finally switching back to the chat.

What's stopping you from getting some?

Adora knew the answer, but Glimmer was endlessly inventive about finding new things she thought would keep her out of the dating pool. It sometimes led to some interesting encounters. Like the speed dates. Which were fine, apart from the occasional creepy dude who wouldn't stop staring at Glimmer's chest. And that all of the guys had opinions about everything, most of which signaled immediately that they were looking for someone to boss around and maybe have mediocre sex with every so often. Okay, so maybe that wasn't fine, but the ice skating was, even if the only person who had walked out of there with the number of the skate rental clerk was Bo. Apparently, knowing what Johnny Weir was wearing was the way to go. Even the pole dancing class had been Adora trying to get Glimmer to be less anxious about everything by swiftly agreeing to do something before Glimmer could talk herself out of it. Glimmer had been sure Ms. Fizz wouldn't take her at all, but Ms. Fizz had whispered a name in her ear and told her to look up her videos online after class. Adora didn't hear the name or see the videos, but they had Glimmer convinced. And Glimmer was a lot better than when she had started, that much was obvious. It would really only be a matter of time before she caught the attention of someone who was worthy of her and could help talk Glimmer through the small panics she usually got when she thought that someone might be interested in her that way.

> I'd like them to stop staring at my athletic friend and thinking of me only when they find out she's not interested in them.

Adora fought the urge to keysmash into the chat.

> They're looking at me after a while because I dance like I don't care whether or not I'm good at it! When we walk in to places, they're looking at you a lot more than me. Even when I try to dress up, I look like I'm going to the gym. You look like you're going to make every girl jealous of you.

Glimmer looked annoyed at that, rather than pleased.

I would believe you more if anyone actually talked to me when we went out.

Adora shrugged. It was probably a coincidence, but Adora liked to believe that Glimmer's lack of conversation partners was because it was a rare type of person that would neither be intimidated by Adora's ability to out-dude most dudes nor Bo's impeccably on-point yet effortless presentation that hid a fiercely smart mind that could out-nerd most nerds. Most days, Glimmer appreciated her Best Friend Squad being her wingpeople, but it had been a while since they had gone anywhere.

Before she had to respond, the lecture finished for the class. Both of them stayed a bit after, finishing up their notes before running off to their next classes on opposite ends of the same building. Adora knew Glimmer wasn't going to drop the issue, but spending some time away from it often helped everyone get their perspective back.

"Kyle, goddammit, stop getting in my sightline! If I get hurt because of you…" Kat snarled.

"Break time!" Lonnie hollered. "Take five, get some water, come back fresh." In a quieter voice she added, "Kat, talk to you for a second?"

Kat nodded and stayed back while the rest of the group headed to retrieve their water.

"What's going on?" Lonnie asked. "You're usually more tolerant of Kyle's faults."

"I'm not looking forward to getting whipped by Scorpia because Kyle keeps putting himself between me and her," Kat grumbled.

"You do remember that Kyle is the first one who gets his tail snapped, right? By the time the whip comes your way, it's just you and her."

Kat stared for a moment before facepalming. "Ugh, you're right," she said, running her hands through her hair. "And why do I care? I can see over him when I'm on the pole, anyway."

"Yep. Not like it's Rogelio in your view. *Damn*, I wish that man would just pick me up and bench press me a couple times."

"Wouldn't know anything about that," Kat said. "Besides, seems like his taste is in tiny twinks he could snap in two."

"Yeah, I know," Lonnie grumbled. "He and Kyle seem pretty happy together, but a girl can dream, can't she?"

Kat shrugged. "I can't think about that after a shift like today's."

"How many guys got grabby at you?"

"Six. Six assholes nearly made me lose my job because 'corporate' decided we should all be falling out of our uniforms and all the idiots want a piece. A couple of them even threatened to 'complain about the service to my manager' in addition to not leaving a tip."

"Wow," Kyle said, eyes wide. "I'm sorry, Kat."

Kat turned to yell at him for eavesdropping, but realized she and Lonnie had wandered enough in their talk that Kyle had probably just overheard her.

"Thanks," she said instead, and stalked over to her own water bottle. She was about to say something more to Kyle when a couple of arms encircled her from behind and squeezed her in a crushing hug.

"Such rude boys," Elaine said lightly from behind Kat. "Can't keep their hands to themselves and don't know how to tip properly? Their mommas did not raise them right."

"I don't know how she does that without getting punched in the face," Lonnie said quietly to Kyle. Kyle shrugged his own lack of

understanding.

"Hello, Lonnie. Hello, Kyle," Elaine said over Kat's shoulder. "Thank you for looking after her."

"Ma'am," Lonnie replied.

"Let go of me," Kat said, squirming. Elaine did, and Kat glared at her. "You're one to talk about keeping your hands to yourself."

"Do you want me to stop?" Elaine asked seriously.

"…No." Kat replied after thinking about it for a while. She'd seriously considered saying yes, and maybe if it had been in front of anyone other than Kyle and Lonnie, she would have said yes, just to try and keep her reputation intact. But Elaine and Lonnie had seen all of her moods, and Kyle had been the recipient of many of them, so there wasn't any way that she could bluff them into believing she was stronger and fiercer than she often felt. And Elaine knew that it would be a bluff, so she would call it as much as possible with unexpected hugging time until Kat admitted she liked having friends who would give her hugs when she was feeling awful.

"You let me know if that changes," Elaine said. "For now, though, Lonnie, could we try again on the same routine?"

"Yes, ma'am."

When they had reassembled, Elaine took a look at the layout and frowned. "Kyle, hon, can you give me a better look? I don't want to hit *you*, I want to hit that beautiful target you're presenting to me."

Kyle nodded nervously, then smiled warmly as Rogelio put a reassuring hand on his shoulder and whispered something in his ear. When he straightened his posture after Rogelio returned to his own spot, Elaine grinned.

"That's it! Just like that, always," she said, and then threw a perfect strike that made Kyle jump from the sound and the feeling of his well-padded prosthetic tail taking the impact of the whip.

Kat smiled from behind a hand as she stretched and spun, trying to remember what she had seen Adora doing in their last class. Her assigned partner from the last class was still gathering confidence that she could spin without falling off, which left the high spaces to Kat to use for herself and to watch and see what the other woman was up to. There had been a lot of showing and encouraging and spotting, but at one point when her partner had gone to get some water, Adora had jumped on and found her way into a spin where she was completely parallel to the ground, spinning with both arms out and her legs as the only points of contact with the pole. Kat had been trying to do the same thing all rehearsal, but she never felt stable enough to let go all the way and believe that she wouldn't just fall down and hit her head on the floor or the pole. She was partially convinced that it worked for Adora because Adora was ignorant of how the laws of physics worked, because the more times she tried it and either balked or fell, the more it seemed a move that worked by will rather than by technique.

That seemed to describe Adora pretty accurately, really, the more she thought about it. She liked to throw herself around on the pole, ponytail flying behind her in a desperate attempt to keep up. Adora really seemed to adopt the idea that their pole dancing classes were meant to be an athletic workout, and any other value they might have were secondary. She would have long since dismissed Adora as a dumb jock, except dumb jocks didn't do pole dance classes. Plus, Ms. Fizz had pointed Adora out on the first day of the new class and suggested that Kat could learn several useful things from Adora and the way she approached the class. So there was clearly something there that Ms. Fizz expected her to learn, but it wasn't obvious to Kat yet what it was supposed to be.

She almost didn't see Elaine take up her position near Kat, but thankfully, she'd been spinning in a way that would have made it

easy for Elaine to do her part, throwing her whip in a way that looked like a near miss to the audience, but wouldn't actually get anywhere near her. The routine was supposed to be timed so that Kat would leap between the two poles set on stage, with Elaine's whip appearing to pass through the spot she had just left. Since she was already late on the jump, Kat decided to slide down the pole and pass underneath Elaine's whip as it cracked in the air above her, then leap to the other pole and climb up as Elaine's second strike landed behind her.

The nice thing about working with Elaine is that she never seemed to be worried about anything, if things started to go off script. Even though it was a later rehearsal, and Lonnie might joke about being distracted at her afterward, Elaine always behaved like whatever happened was just part of the show. Frankly, Kat couldn't imagine how someone could just accept what was happening in front of them and react accordingly. It either took a lot of skill that Kat couldn't truly appreciate, or Elaine had a lot of trust that everything would end up in the right place at the right time. Which was more in line with Elaine's personality.

Kat completed her last transition as Elaine snapped the last intentional miss, before slowly spinning her way down the pole. One cute pose to pop her butt out and give Elaine a nice target to hit, one hand hidden on the quick-release catch on her tail belt. She undid the catch at the last moment before the whip caught the tail, giving the illusion that Elaine had snapped it right off her. There was enough breeze from that move that Kat wondered whether she'd be flashing the audience in the short fox-colored skirt she'd be wearing for the performance. That would be something she'd have to keep in mind, so she could react accordingly. Sometimes the audience was more appreciative if they thought they'd gotten away with seeing something they weren't supposed to, and if she acted like she was trying to cover up, it might make one of the gags later work better.

"Hey, Elaine, can you make that breeze happen every time?"

"Can't really stop it," she replied.

Kat grinned. She could spin this into something later on with her solo pole routine.

It was just her luck that Adora was in the same lecture time as her for Women Stabbing Men. The actual course had a more academic-sounding name, sure, but based on the syllabus and the reading list, Kat was sure her name was just as accurate as whatever had been put in the course catalog to hide its true nature.

Thankfully, she hadn't been put in the same discussion section as Adora or any of her friends. That should have given her plenty of time to think her situation over, but Kat had learned early on that she wasn't good at keeping an internal monologue running. Her thought processes did better when there was someone to absorb them, and Elaine wasn't available.

"Kyle! Get over here," she hissed. Kyle raised his eyebrows, but came over to her. "How many of those guys who got stabbed in the Hat Pin Panic deserved it?"

"What?" Kyle replied. "We're—we're not even to that part of the reading yet."

Kat laughed. Kyle wasn't great at a lot of things; He spooked easily, he had trouble keeping up with some of the more physical stunts, and his crush on Rogelio was so obvious that Kat had more than once considered sticking a "Date Me" sign on his back just so the rest of them didn't have to watch Kyle moon so much and never work up the courage to say anything.

"But for the record," Kyle continued, "most of them."

One thing Kyle was excellent at, though, was his studies, so Kat had a feeling that Kyle would have read ahead and could respond intelligently to a question they weren't going to ask for weeks.

"You nerd," Kat said. "What are you doing reading ahead? Shouldn't you have a life or something?"

"Did you want to talk about the actual assignment, Kat?" Kyle asked. "If not, I'm going to go get some coffee first."

Kat glared at him, but Kyle shrugged and slipped out. Depending on the line at the only decent coffee shop close to the student union, Kyle could take anywhere from five minutes to an hour to get the coffee that he said he was going to. And that assumed he was actually getting coffee, and not some blended drink that said there was coffee in it, but barely tasted like it over the sugar, whipped cream, caramel, chocolate syrup, and milk. It was the perfect kind of drink for Kyle, but it also took forever to make, even when there wasn't anyone in line in front of him.

"Like he was trying to avoid me," she muttered.

"Might have been," someone said next to her. Kat looked over to the side the voice had come from and saw someone who looked vaguely familiar to her. Not enough to say exactly who, but it was probably someone from one of her lectures. If she'd been interested in men, he would have been good enough to look at for a while, but there was something about the way he was dressed and the care he seemed to take in his appearance that suggested that he would be high maintenance for whichever girl managed to get him. "Need a study partner?" he asked.

"No," she said, which was honest enough. The assignment and the reading hadn't been difficult, so she didn't need anyone to help with that. What she *wanted* was someone to talk with about was going on in her life, and Kyle was one of the few people she could intimidate into forgetting anything important or embarrassing that she might have said accidentally.

"You look like you could use a friendly ear," he said, sounding concerned for someone he'd never met before this.

"Not interested," she said. "In sympathy or in boys."

"Oh," he said, and then Kat saw the lights turn on. "Oh! I'm sorry, I didn't mean to give that impression. I hope you can find

someone to talk to, though. There's free student counseling services, if it's big," he said, before waving to her and finding another table to sit at. Kat buried her head in her arms at the table. If this was how her period in between classes was going to go, she might as well join the coffee line behind Kyle. At least at the end of *that* painful interaction she'd have something she could enjoy.

Her gaze shifted back to the man who had offered her a listening ear. He seemed happy enough, flipping back and forth between a couple pages in one of his books, as he took notes on his laptop. She hadn't noticed what book he was looking at, but it looked like something that would have been available at any of the bookstores in town, instead of the textbook sections. He still looked familiar to her, but that could mean anything. Maybe he was one of the parkour guys who went running through her practice space every day. She wasn't…embarrassed, necessarily, to practice her spins around them, but they always seemed to want to show off for her with the way they used all of the equipment for flips and spins of their own. She'd watched one of them faceplant thinking he could fling himself out of one of the swings and turn a flip before he came back down to earth. Before she had to worry whether he'd actually hurt himself, he was back up and running with the rest of them, laughing at himself for missing the trick. She'd never really been able to bond with people like that, laughing and just continuing after humiliating themselves like that. Adora hadn't crashed herself yet, but there were times where it looked like she might, and she had the same dopey grin in her face that those runners did. No big deal, shake it off, try it again some other time. Like there weren't consequences to messing up. Kat shivered and shook herself. Her mother wasn't here at university, and there was no reason to believe that any mistakes she made here would get back home.

But Adora absolutely would pop back up after falling off, jumping back on to try it again. Maybe even a few more times—even if she didn't have a prayer of being able to pull off the thing she wanted to do. Kat laughed to herself. Just another way that Adora kept trying to will things into existence she had no business being able

to do. Well, at least, the Adora that she'd met so far would do all of that. Maybe the actual Adora was different. Class partner Adora would have been really nice to have as a friend back home, Kat thought. Even if she was a complete meathead, she still would have been fun. They could have gotten into trouble together, and Kat would always have been able to ditch her right before anyone told her mother what had happened. It would have been a perfect pairing.

"Coffee?" Kyle asked, setting a cup down in front of her as he interrupted her thoughts.

"…yeah….Thanks, Kyle," Kat said before taking a careful sip. She was pleasantly surprised to find it was unadulterated black. "How much do I owe you?"

"It was on the house," Kyle said. "They were changing out a pot, and the barista told me to give it to you. Said the coffee might help you recognize how cute you are."

Kat took another sip, then turned the cup in her hands to see the name and the telephone number of the barista written on it, a sunshine and granola type that would *definitely* piss Kat off if it turned out that attitude wasn't an act put on for the customers. She had to have a bitchin' hairstylist, though, Kat remembered, since her hair was almost always the same color and pattern of the flowers she wore in it. Maybe she could pretend long enough to get introduced to someone who might be able to tame her rat's nest into something that looked good.

"Better?" Kyle asked after her third sip.

"Yeah." Kat said, waving away the idea of using one of the baristas in the only decent coffee shop on campus as the self-destructive thought it was. "Probably should have brought this to Lonnie, though. Would have had a better chance of getting a call back." Kat pulled the coffee cup away from her nose just long enough to smell what Kyle had in his cup and made a face. "Blech! I can smell the sugar all the way over here!"

Kyle, for his part, took a long drink through the straw, exaggerating his enjoyment of the sickly sweet drink by fluttering his eyes and trying to look coy.

"What are you wasting effort on me for?" Kat said. "Take that act and go flirt with Rogelio or something."

"What, get in line behind Lonnie, who he's probably more interested in?" Kyle said. "No thanks. I'm not going to be someone's rebound relationship." He scooped up his sugar abomination and headed somewhere else. After another sip, Kat decided she really had wanted the coffee more than she'd wanted to talk.

"If that man only knew," Kat grumbled into her cup. "He could have them both if he wanted. Hell, he could probably have them both *at the same time* if they were both cool with it." Until one of the two actually *said something*, though, instead of waiting and assuming Rogelio was interested in the other one, it would continue to be painful to watch. It was actually kind of surprising that Elaine hadn't interfered or tried to push Kyle, Lonnie, or Rogelio together in any way, given how much of an interest she always took in how Kat was doing making friends (and potentially more than friends). Not for the first time, Kat wondered whether Elaine saw her as a charity case or a project of some sort. If she did, though, Elaine never really did much to try and push her or to make her feel like she was inadequate, or take advantage of her. Rolling her eyes at her own thoughts, Kat finished the coffee and chucked the cup into the trash. She'd killed enough time so that she wouldn't be extremely early to her next class, so it was time to walk slowly across the campus to the lecture hall. Sometimes, if she was lucky, she would get to watch the parkour guys play cat and mouse with campus security.

"We're partners," Kat said halfway through their third class together, during one of the breaks.

"That's abrupt," Adora replied. "Don't I get a say in the matter?"

"Look, if we don't pair up, then I'm going to get stuck with the himbo over there who is very clearly unhappy at not getting to do a routine with his girlfriend."

"He's not a himbo, he's just Bo," Adora protested. "And they're not dating."

"Really?" Kat said, tilting her head skeptically. "He hangs all over her and she's completely comfortable around him. If they're not dating, they should be."

This time, it was Adora's turn to tilt her head. "Huh, they've been friends forever. You really think they should go further?"

"You're saying he hasn't tried already?" Kat seemed incredulous. Adora shrugged. "You sure he's got anything in his head…or between his legs?"

"Hey!" Adora swatted Kat on the shoulder. "That's not nice."

Kat snorted. "If he doesn't make a move on her soon, I think she's going to drag him off and explain it to him."

"You seem to know a lot about other people's relationships," Adora said. "Or at least have some opinions about them."

"He tried to talk his way into being my study buddy a little while ago, or at least being a sympathetic ear for me to pour my worries out to."

"Yeah, he's really good at listening," Adora said, hauling herself up high on the pole to practice the ground transition Ms. Fizz had demonstrated for them earlier in the class. The move seemed easy enough to do, hooking her legs and slowly spinning her way to the ground with what was supposed to be a "come hither" gesture and pose that would have let the audience see down her cleavage (if she had any, anyway. Glimmer was the one who had been blessed with a drool-worthy chest), ending with a knee slide away from the pole, but it felt mechanical to her. She'd been trying to sneak a glance back over at Glimmer to see how she

positioned herself through all of it, but Glimmer seemed to have her hands full convincing her partner that she needed to start the move higher up if she wanted to make it to the knee slide without banging her head on the floor first.

"Hey, could you spot me?" she asked Kat. "I want to try that move again, but I feel like I'm rushing through it."

"Yeah, sure," Kat said, seemingly startled by the subject change. Adora climbed her way up and started to spin herself, finally settling into the leg hook that let her eventually float her way down until she was parallel to the floor, hair down and looking at Kat, whose scowl only deepened as she watched Adora spin. Right about the time she felt like she was going too slow to keep herself in place, her leg gave out and she dropped right on her back, luckily keeping her head from bouncing off the mat around the pole.

"Ow," she said. "What happened to my spotter?" she asked.

"Would have had to be on my knees to keep you off the ground," Kat said. She pointed at the mat. "And you had that."

Adora picked herself back up. "Can't blame a woman for wanting something softer to land on," she muttered quietly. "Hey," she said, louder, "if you're not going to catch me, could you stand over there?" Adora indicated about where she would be at the end of the move. "That way, I know how far to slide."

"Fine," Kat said, shrugging, and moved over to the indicated spot.

Adora hauled herself back up on the pole and restarted the move, still trying not to spin too quickly, keeping her focus on Kat. Having a solitary target to focus on helped her control the spin rate: only clanging the pole with her knee pads once as she struggled to get herself back upright, and turning a roll rather than the knee slide that let her transition right back up to standing —a move that conveniently put her right into Kat's personal space. Adora studied Kat's reaction as intently as she could, but the other

woman didn't blush or look away or leer or give away any damn reaction at all.

"You're making it hard to figure out whether I'm doing this correctly," Adora said.

"If you want to give me a lap dance, then sure," Kat replied.

"Do you want one?" Adora challenged.

"Maybe after class," Kat snickered.

Adora turned around and went back to the pole to try the move again, frustration helping her climb higher to try something else. That was the closest she'd gotten to any kind of useful information, and she wasn't actually any closer to understanding. Trying it one more time with the knee slide put her where she would want to be if she were dancing on a stage, so that was helpful, but she was still frustrated at not actually having learned anything about Kat's intentions. Satisfied that she could do the move as part of the routine they were supposed to be building together, Adora let Kat climb up on the pole to try it herself, keeping one eye on Kat's spins and one eye on Glimmer, who was demonstrating again for her partner, a smile on her face as she laughed her way around and down to the end.

Glimmer and Bo together hadn't crossed her mind before, but now that Kat had mentioned it, the idea wouldn't get out of her head without at least a little bit of thought. Bo was a good listener, didn't like conflict, didn't react like he'd been poisoned when watching a rom-com, could articulate his emotions and feelings, could put together an outfit when he wanted to…Adora nearly facepalmed when she realized that she'd made the assumption that Bo was at least some flavor of queer based solely on non-toxic masculinity. He'd learned it all from his dads, so she'd just assumed he would follow in their footsteps. Definitely not her smartest moment.

"Hey, Adora," Kat said in her ear, startling her from her thought, "how about that lap dance?" Kat had snuck up on her while she was distracted and was far more in Adora's space than she had been in Kat's. Seeing that she'd startled Adora, Kat started laughing at her as she danced away back to the pole.

Seeing aside her chagrin at her assumptions about Bo, Adora refocused her attention on Kat, studying the moves she was doing and trying to figure out how they could be incorporated into a pairs act. It was clear that Kat preferred to work on the higher half of the pole, which was fine with Adora, but Kat didn't seem to be using any of the good references on the walls to anchor herself. Her eyes seemed locked on Adora whenever she could, only sliding away when it seemed obvious that Adora was looking at her. Whatever Kat was studying in her, she hadn't found it yet, apparently. She would have to soon, though, if they were going to do something that looked like it was one performance, instead of two people doing separate routines in the same space.

Check your e-mail.

Adora switched away from the chat immediately. She didn't need a distraction in the middle of the lecture, and Glimmer telling her to check her e-mail was absolutely going to be a distraction.

Kat invited us all to a party.

That couldn't be right. Kat was pretty anti-social around the other members of Ms. Fizz's class. She didn't seem like the type to suddenly change direction and decide she wanted to throw a bash somewhere. Before she could follow that thought too far anywhere, Adora told herself to refocus on the lecture and that whatever was happening could wait until outside of class to be dealt with. Glimmer was just trying to pull her off of studying because she couldn't keep her mythological figures straight and wanted someone else to alleviate her boredom.

She's going to be stripping on stage.

Now Adora *knew* that Glimmer was trying to fuck with her. There was no way that Kat would send out something like that. Adora was pretty sure she wouldn't do anything like that, given how guarded she was about her life outside of their classes. Kat had told her when they met that she didn't have much spare time outside of being a student, taking part in Ms. Fizz's pole class, and work, so while it was possible that Kat was also a hardcore party girl, that didn't seem to be the kind of thing someone would broadcast all over the Internet.

Adora tried to re-focus on the lecture, but the thought of Kat strutting on a stage in heels and her workout clothes popped into her head to continue trying to distract her. Adora admitted to herself that she should probably put Kat in something better, but there wasn't anything else she had seen Kat in that would give her a different image to work with. Even her class outfits, when Adora had sat closer to the front to spy on her, seemed focused mostly on comfort instead of caring about whether someone thought she looked good. Unbidden, the idea of Kat in a tuxedo and bow tie on a stage, dancing with Adora in a dress popped into her head. She couldn't quite place the soundtrack, but she was pretty sure it was some sort of old time musical number. It was a fun visual, but it was a distraction, and Adora still needed to focus on the lecture. She could almost hear Glimmer growl in frustration that her ploy still wasn't working.

> There's going to be a kiss to the lucky hero that gets to be on stage to save the day.

That… that wasn't possible. The thought that some frat boy might get on stage and Kat would willingly kiss him? The mere thought of it was enough to make Adora want to march down to Kat and ask her what she was thinking. Adora clicked open the e-mail that had been sent from Ms. Fizz, and stared at the show flier it contained. Adora knew Glimmer was smirking at having finally succeeded in distracting her, but at this point, Adora had to know what was going on.

"Dance of the seven tails," she murmured quietly to herself, "damsel in distress…Scorpia's stinger, wait, *the* Mistress Scorpia? Holy shit…" Adora came to the end of the flier, and then gave an angry glare at Glimmer, who took a single look and began busying herself in note taking on her own computer.

There's nothing in here about audience participation!

Adora tried to focus on the lecture again, but she was still upset with Glimmer for goading her into looking at the advertisement for the burlesque show, and the possibilities that might entail, including, apparently, several new possible outfits for Kat that her brain had come up with after reading.

Guess you'll have to save it for after the show, then.

Adora pointedly closed the chat window. Glimmer could suffer the silent treatment for everything she did. Especially since she knew that, by putting it in front of Adora's face, she'd basically guaranteed all of them would be at the show. And that Adora would have to endure being eyebrow waggled at by Glimmer every time Kat was on stage. And the very real possibility that she would see Kat in an entirely new context from their pole class. Which might enrich her fantasy life a lot, but would make it much harder to interact with Kat in the real one.

She could hope, of course, that all the interest Kat had shown in making a good duo and in talking with her meant that she had a more personal interest in Adora—but that was all that it was, a hope. Adora was sure Kat would have a boyfriend soon enough, especially once she had a good pole routine to entice him with. And she would have to try not to be jealous of him.

Glimmer's words came back to her, giving her a vision of being the dashing hero coming to the rescue, sweeping in with a sword against the stinger and claws of a giant scorpion that Kat struggled to free herself from. Adora tried to picture the right expression on Kat's face. She couldn't imagine Kat looking distressed or helpless. She would probably be annoyed at it, and

trying hard to get out of the claws herself. And probably wondering why she decided to wear a dress that day, instead of something more sensible to have an adventure with. Would Adora even rescue her, or would she just end up being enough of a distraction for Kat to escape on her own and then run away even further? Kat certainly seemed like the kind of person who wouldn't wait for anyone to come rescue her. She'd gotten right in Adora's space and felt completely comfortable there, doing what Adora had tried to do to her so easily. As much as Adora wanted to be the person who would be assertive in a relationship, Kat seemed like someone who would never back down or show any weakness. Even if they just stayed friends, it was likely that Kat was going to be the one who wanted to lead. Was that something she could allow? Glimmer had told Adora that she was pretty intense when she got competitive. That might be true of Kat, too. No wonder they were having trouble creating a routine where they had to work together. Kat would have done better with Bo. Even if she didn't think he was as intelligent as he actually was.

Adora focused back in on the lecture, reading over the notes she had been typing while her brain had been letting itself get distracted by thinking about her relationship with Kat. Nothing seemed out of place, but she knew that this lecturer often wove in puns or misleading statements as a way of trying to make the students pay more attention.

> Send me your notes after this lecture. It's your fault for distracting me.

Glimmer had the good grace to look like she was at least contemplating feeling ashamed for what same had done, even if her next message proved she felt no such thing.

> So we're going, right? I feel like we should dress up for it. Just in case we get called on stage to be heroes or something.

Adora pointedly rolled her eyes in Glimmer's direction.

There isn't going to be any audience participation for this. I know *you* have dreams about rescuing someone and taking them home, but *I* plan on watching it all unfold.

Glimmer smirked back at her.

Even if it's Kat who needs rescuing?

Adora went back to her own note taking, pretty sure she was going to have to ask Bo for his notes on this lecture, since he was the only one who hadn't been drawn into this ridiculous discussion. How he managed to stay above it all was a mystery to her, but she appreciated his fortitude all the more every time Glimmer managed to get her off track. Which was absolutely what she was trying to do with this question. Even if her imagination seemed more than ready to rise to the challenge again, this time with the possibility of Kat tied to one of their practice poles, trying to dodge whip strikes from an inky blackness and an evil laugh.

All of it was nonsense, of course. She'd watched Mistress Scorpia do all sorts of very fancy whip tricks online, including one of them where she cut off the end of a cigar in someone's mouth. She didn't seem like the kind of person who would just whip someone as part of a comic book kind of villainy. Unless they wanted it, anyway, and if they wanted it, they probably needed to pony up a lot more than what most college students could make. Which led to a completely different thought of Kat using her pole skills at one of the local dives for tips. Which, well, if it was what she wanted to do and she could make enough money at it… Adora wanted Kat to be working a classier space than those places, somewhere that the frat boys wouldn't be scoping out to see if they recognized someone they could intimidate or blackmail into being their own personal performer. It would be a long commute to get to and from somewhere the students (and faculty) would visit, but if the tips were enough, it might be worth it. From what little Adora had heard Kat complaining about her job, wherever she was working now, the tips definitely were not worth it.

Adora shook her head and tried to return to the lecture. Why was she so concerned about someone who was just her pole class partner and who apparently also participated in a burlesque act in her spare time? They weren't romantic partners, or even friends. Adora had thought she was better than falling for a pretty face, but apparently that wasn't the case when it came to Kat. She had a crush, and if this was what having a crush was like, then Adora was more than ready to never have another one of them until after she was done with the more important things in her life, like passing her classes. She grumbled as outfit possibilities for the night started to try and intrude on her focus, but managed to get them out of her head by promising herself that she would devote time to thinking about clothes and matching and all of that when she had actual time to sit in front of her computer and do it, after all her homework was done. Even though her notes were a mess at this point, and she would definitely have to get Bo's to have a prayer of understanding this week's lecture.

"Yeah, fine, she's cute," Kat said.

"That's all you're going to say?" Elaine asked. "She's cute?"

"She's also got way too much energy, she knows everyone in the class, I swear, and she's still *blonde*. There's no way someone that perky would be interested in this, so I shouldn't get my hopes up."

"She sounds exactly like the kind of person horny university boys would want to see do pole work on stage," Elaine said, making sure her corset was properly tied in front, "not that I have any experience at what horny university boys want these days."

"Yeah, me neither," Kat said, bending down to strap on her heels. "Ugh, goddammit, why can't I get some nice stompy boots like you? It's really hard to play sexy when you're concerned about falling over instead."

"It messes with the suspension of disbelief," Elaine told her. Kat looked at her with her own disbelief. "What? Believe it or not, I have a university degree. I learned things."

"Okay," Kat said, still skeptical. "I still hate these heels, though."

"They look good on you," Elaine said, smiling a little at the glare Kat gave her in response, before tilting her head to look at Kat again. "Maybe for the next show, we can try and find some tie-ups? I think you might feel more stable in shoes with crisscrossing straps up your leg."

"Whatever," Kat snorted. "Doubt anyone is looking at my legs anyway."

"They should be," Elaine said. "They're well-muscled, they help you look taller, and they're right at eye level for anyone looking to admire you on stage in those heels."

"As opposed to the significantly bustier woman in the corset wielding the whip. You're basically the audience's idea of a fetish model. Why would anyone be looking at me?"

"They don't look at the lion tamer, hon, they look at the whip, and where the whip is going. I mean, sure, there's probably one or two in the audience that want me to do the routine with them, and to actually hit them, instead of getting dangerously close, but you're the person in peril from my on-stage villainy," Elaine said, cackling and wiggling her fingers. "They're all looking at you and thinking how much they want to rescue you from me and take you home."

"Yeah, okay," Kat said, setting the fox ear headband onto her head and tucking it into her hair so it wouldn't move. "How do I look?"

"Break a leg, tiger," Elaine said. "I'll be along to sting you shortly."

Kat pointed at the ears as she walked semi-steadily out of the dressing room. Within a couple minutes, she was back inside.

"Shit, she's actually here," Kat said by way of explanation. "What is she doing here?"

"I'm pretty sure you said you invited all the people in your pole dance class to see you perform."

"Oh, that must be it. Yeah, she's here with the purple-haired Jem lookalike and the himbo that hangs around both of them. They're just curious about seeing the performance. Good talk," she finished, turning back around and leaving again.

Kat made it to her spot just as Lonnie was wrapping up her introduction and explanation of the sights and sounds (but mostly sights) that were going to be part of the night's entertainment. Seeing Kat in place, Lonnie gave her a wink that coincided with the phrase "more beauty and comedy than your average varieté," drawing some cheers from the audience.

"And because we don't believe in keeping people waiting, let's get right into it with our first act. Or first performer is ready to help you get properly in the mood for later. He's always providing just as much spice as he can handle when he performs, so give it up for the warm-up!"

Kyle ran on to the stage, shirtless and in short shorts, carrying a few batons loosely in his arms. The audience went silent, not fully sure what to do with the possibility of this, and there was even less noise as Kyle began to spin the batons around, spreading some sort of liquid all over the stage with his somewhat basic spinning effort. Kat watched as the audience shifted a bit, clearly having expected something more flashy than this.

"Can't you do something like light them on fire?" someone from the audience heckled.

"Oh, good idea," Kyle said, as if that hasn't been the exact cue he was waiting for, and clicked the batons so they lit on fire, spinning them much more quickly and touching his batons to fire the lines of alcohol he had been spreading around at the beginning.

Weaving through the now obvious flame lines as they caught, Kyle began to spin his batons more seriously and skillfully. The audience began to cheer what they had strongly considered booing, now that they saw the real act planned for them.

Kat shook her head. She still didn't understand how Kyle could manage to be completely awkward when he was trying to be serious, but when Kyle wanted to make fun of himself, he could do things that made her blink twice. She could feel the heat of the flames from Kyle's routine as he worked up both a sweat and the energy of the crowd with his spinning until, finally, red all over from the exertion (and hopefully not from having caught any of himself on fire), all the flames went out and only Kyle was left on the stage. They'd planned and rehearsed it a few times to make sure there weren't going to be any smoke alarms going off or fire suppression systems kicking in, but there was always the possibility that the warm up act would be the last act of the night. Kyle trusted his fire not to smoke, and as much as Kat would never admit it in front of anyone else, she did trust Kyle to know his fire.

As Kyle ran off to get himself cooled off for his next role, Lonnie came back on to introduce Rogelio and his act. Rogelio had commissioned a wandering samurai's outfit that, with the bandage cloth sewn in where the holes in the outfit were strategically placed, fit him in exactly the right ways that left just enough for the imagination to do wonders. Kat had certainly heard enough of Lonnie's imagination to get a clear picture of what she wanted to do with him, and in that outfit, Kat could understand why both Lonnie and Kyle became shrinking violets at the possibility of expressing their interest in him.

Rogelio's patter was about how he had always wanted to be a fierce warrior, but as much as he had trained and tried, he couldn't stop from flinching when people fought him, indicating the patches on his clothes as the results of his inability to keep focus, while assuring the audience that he was never seriously hurt. How nearly losing skin to the many quests he'd been on transitioned into discovering he enjoyed showing off a little skin

never fully made sense to Kat, but Rogelio was so smooth in his delivery he never gave anyone a reason to stop and think about what he was saying. Especially once he started dancing. Rogelio knew everything that his costume showed and obscured and how to move so that he could change what was on display to which part of the audience. He'd had suggestions on how to use the lighting in the venue so they could highlight the depths and shadows of his and Lonnie's darker skin tones. Which conveniently made Kyle look pasty and washed out, exactly the way he was supposed to be as the comic relief.

Thinking about him apparently was the cue for Kyle to appear, running from something off stage, tripping over his own feet and crashing to a halt in front of Rogelio. The loose story they told for this show was about a fox god and a scorpion god, with Rogelio playing the role of the warrior tasked with resolving the dispute so that the villagers near the fight would be able to live their lives without the fear of stingers, pincers, or tricksters. Kyle was one of the small foxes asking for protection from the scorpions, and Kat and Elaine were the respective big gods having the problem with each other.

If anyone was paying attention to the story, though, they'd all agreed it meant there wasn't enough eye candy providing a distraction. As soon as Kyle and Rogelio left, Elaine and Kat came on to do their part, which involved a lot of teasing and swagger, mostly for the audience's benefit, and Elaine threatening to use her stinger on the mischievous foxes before uncorking a strike that ruffled Kat's hair with the breeze as it passed over her head while she was shaking her tails at her. This one was the crackerless whip, so there was no loud boom to assault her ears with. It had still taken Kat a long time to believe and then trust that Elaine could throw that closely that consistently, but Elaine never disappointed her.

While she was twerking her tails at Elaine, Kat snuck a glance over at Adora. Adora was sitting at the edge of her seat and… looking worried. She was supposed to be enjoying the show, not looking like someone had nearly whipped her. Her purple-haired

friend had stars in her eyes at everything, it looked like. Even the himbo looked more engaged with the show than her. There wasn't time to dwell on it much more than that, though, because the show needed to keep going, and she had tails to check on.

After making sure that all the tails were accounted for, Kat muttered her hope that Kyle would be able to hit his spots and give Elaine a workable target before stepping back out into the stage. Climbing up to the poles she'd been practicing on all this time, she did a couple of slow moves to make sure everything was sturdy and would support her. Looking out at the audience, they all seemed focused on—ooh, yeah, Lonnie and Rogelio were getting a good grind on. Kyle was probably getting more jealous about their shared role by the second.

Adora, however, was staring at *her* instead. Despite Lonnie and Rogelio oozing sexuality together. Maybe Elaine was right about who people wanted to look at. Well, while everyone else was looking away, Kat could put on a semi-private show for Adora. She tucked a leg onto the pole and let herself hang there, hair and tails down, giving Adora all the sights she would want to see. Adora's hands flexed in her seat, shifting herself even more forward to stare. Kat laughed to herself as she came back upright, placing her feet on the pole and spinning just quickly enough to keep them easily in contact. It was…exciting to be able to tease Adora like this, with her unable to try and respond or to one up her, like she usually did in their pole class together. If Adora could learn to let go and not have to be in control all the time, Kat thought, she might find out she enjoyed just experiencing things. Kat decided to show off what she had been working on for her half of their pair routine, something that Adora could mirror or respond to her with. Maybe with a few more splits and things meant to show off her tails, but Adora would fill in what was being covered over. It was a tease, and they both knew it, and as far as she could tell, Adora seemed to be enjoying the whole thing just as much as she was.

Two whip cracks and a thump took Kat's attention away from Adora and back to the show on the floor, Kyle sprinting away from

Elaine, his tail on the floor as intended. That part had gone off without a hitch. Lonnie and Rogelio would do their part, symbolically staying out of the way of Elaine's sight so she couldn't sting them with the long whip that was now coiled at her hip. Elaine had a smaller whip to use for both of them that would uncoil and touch their tails much faster than the flashier and bigger whip she'd snapped offstage and thumped Kyle's tail with to announce herself. It would have been serious, beautiful, dramatic, and tragic, if it weren't for the way that Lonnie and Rogelio's really sold the mischief aspects of being foxes, getting the audience to laugh along at their gags before Elaine inevitably snapped their tails as well, usually getting a laugh of her own as she dispatched them to the wings, leaving just Kat and her on stage together.

Giving Adora a glance disguised as a dismissive look at Elaine, Kat smiled to herself to see Adora shrunk back into her chair and looking pretty flustered, fidgeting with her hands, while her purple-haired friend seemed to be grinning at her expense. Kat gave Adora a wink and then went into the strut and pole routine she'd practiced with Elaine so many times before. Keeping her balance in the heels and remembering Elaine's advice on how to make herself attractive to the audience seemed easier if she focused on trying to embarrass Adora as much as possible with everything she did and every pose she struck. Elaine seemed to pick up on the idea, keeping her short whip out so as to increase the "danger" as Kat floated from pole to pole, sliding, stretching, and flexing, while laughing and throwing sultry looks and winks at the audience.

When she saw Elaine go for the big whip, Kat set herself up for the big finale, giving Elaine a nice easy target to hit and letting the tails fly when she thumped them with the whip, the breeze fluttering the skirt beautifully to make sure Adora (and most of the rest of the audience) saw the orange bloomers she'd put on underneath. She slunk off with a pout for the audience as they whistled and cheered what they had seen. The stunned look on Adora's face, even as everyone around her was whooping from the show, made everything that much better. She was looking

forward to the next class with her so they could discuss their routine together, now that she had an idea what was possible.

There were still some acts to do before the show was done, mostly involving Kat looking pretty on the opposite end of a bench from Lonnie as Rogelio lifted it in the air, but Kat felt pretty sure that Adora was only going to remember what had just happened on stage.

"That was awesome!" Glimmer gushed as they were waiting for the rest of the audience to file out. "Even the warm-up act was pretty hot."

Bo laughed as he realized the joke Glimmer had made. "I didn't know we had that many talented students here. Maybe we should audition, Glimmer."

"No way," Glimmer said. "If you want to get nearly naked on stage, I'll buy front row seats, but I'm not letting them laugh at me."

"You'd be great at it, Glimmer," Adora said. "You're bright and sparkly and they'd love you."

"She speaks!" Glimmer said in mock surprise. "I thought that whip routine had fried your brain completely."

Adora gave Glimmer an annoyed look.

"So, got any better ideas about what you might want to do with Kat now?" Glimmer said, grinning to make her double meaning unmistakable.

Adora rolled her eyes at Glimmer. "As far as I know, she's still very sexy—straight, so—"

"—why not go find out?" Glimmer said. "They're right there on stage."

"They probably have post-show stuff to do," Adora said. "We shouldn't intrude on them."

Glimmer had already left to the stage before Adora had finished her sentence. Sighing, Adora followed her down to where everyone seemed to be chatting.

A look seemed to pass between everyone as she approached, and without anyone saying anything, Adora found herself in the group of performers, closest to Kat and the woman who had been flicking a whip at her for most of the night.

"Holy shit, you're Mistress Scorpia," Adora exclaimed. Then, realizing a second later what she had said, and how loud it had been, she added, much more quietly, "Wow. Your whip work is legendary."

"I just finished giving a performance, thank you," Mistress Scorpia said, "so you can call me Elaine, instead."

Adora shoot a questioning look at Kat, who shrugged. "Yeah," Kat said, "she means it. She's always this informal with everyone when she's not performing."

"Well, uh, okay, Elaine," Adora said. "I'm Adora, and that's Glimmer and Bo over there."

"I'm delighted to finally meet you," Elaine said, smiling at Adora. "I've heard quite a bit about you already."

"Oh?" Adora looked equally confused and concerned at this revelation.

"It's all been good," Elaine clarified. "I see why Kat has such trouble around you."

"Trouble?" Glimmer said, perking up immediately and turning back toward their group. "What kind of trouble?"

"Don't mind her," Adora said quickly. "She lives on an unhealthy amount of gossip."

"Perhaps we should compare notes," Elaine said mischievously.

"*No*," Adora and Kat said together, to answering grins from both Glimmer and Elaine.

Kat sighed. "Now you know they're going to do it."

Adora matched Kat's sigh with one of her own. "Yep. You're going to learn so many embarrassing and completely untrue things about me."

"Sounds familiar," Kat replied. "Although, I've never known Elaine to lie, just exaggerate."

"I'm sure Glimmer will find something to match her with, story for story," Adora said.

"So, how did you like the show?" Elaine said. "Isn't Kat the cutest little fox you ever saw?" Kat glared at Elaine.

"I think Adora was thinking of something more than 'cute,' especially after that pole dance routine with the whips," Glimmer replied, cheerfully ignoring Adora's promise of murder in her expression. "I've never seen her so red in my life. I think she might have died from what she saw when you took her tails off."

"Oh, that? That was all Kat's idea, a little extra tease for the audience."

So it had been part of the act after all, Adora thought. A little extra for everyone. It was a bit of a relief to understand that Kat hadn't specifically intended to—

"It looked like she wanted to be real sure Adora couldn't miss what was on offer," Glimmer was saying.

"Looked that way to me, too," Lonnie said. Kyle and Rogelio both nodded along.

Kat rolled her eyes and got up. "I'm going to get more drinks."

"I'll come with you," Adora said. After a beat, she added, "You might need an extra pair of hands to carry things."

"Sure," Kat said after a little bit, and they walked backstage.

"They're really giving you a hard time there," Adora said.

"Yeah, well, it's not like I don't do the same thing to them. It makes the whole thing better in the end."

"I'll say," Adora said. "I was really scared that Elaine was going to hit you." Kat swing her head around to look at Adora, clearly surprised by the remark.

"I wasn't in any danger," Kat said quickly. "We practiced that routine so much and Elaine never came close."

"I know that, but I wanted to just jump on stage and save you. It's a stupid idea, but I… couldn't help it." Kat still looked surprised at her. "I'm sorry," she said. "It was a stupid thought."

"Whatever," Kat said, running her hands through her hair. Adora thought she heard her mutter "God damn it, Elaine," under her breath afterward, but it was too quiet to be sure.

Even when she was aggravated, Kat was still really cute up close. And with nobody around to overhear them, this would be the perfect time to ask about her preferences.

"Hey, there's a question I've got to ask you," Adora said.

Kat gave her a bored look, but didn't say anything.

"Or not," Adora mumbled to herself, her confidence rushing away at Kat's indifference to her.

"No, I don't do this professionally," Kat said. "Elaine's the closest to any of us who does."

"No, that's not it," Adora said.

"Hold these," Kat said, shoving some cans into Adora's hands.

"Wait, wait," Adora said, trying to collect herself properly. Kat scooped up another couple of cans for herself and began heading back out front. "I just wanted to know if you were interested in women, like, sexually, or romantically, or…"Adora trailed off, any further words stuck in her throat and unwilling to come out, her brain having caught up and frantically signaled about what was being said.

Kat took both cans from Adora's hands and headed back out to the front to distribute them without saying anything. When she was out of sight, Adora sighed. "Great job, Adora," she said to herself. "Couldn't think of anything smoother to say about that? Maybe something more subtle than, 'Hi, I'm a lesbian and I think you're hot but I've been terrified that you're straight and would see me coming in to you as weird or that you'd be mortified that you give off those kinds of vibes.' And now, because I've said it that bluntly, I can't pass it off as some kind of joke in really poor taste, ha ha, of course you're straight, how clumsy of me not to notice. Why do I do this to myself?"

"Hah! Pay up, suckers!" Lonnie's voice shouted before Elaine strolled into the backstage area, looking past Adora to the table where the drinks were, as if she were expecting to see Kat there.

"Kat just went back on stage," Adora explained. "What was *that* about?"

Elaine waved a hand dismissively. "Nothing important. Little bit of a wagering pool going on, that's all, about—you know, that doesn't seem like a very polite thing to discuss right now," she said, thinking better of finishing the original train of thought running in her head. "How are you feeling, hon?"

"Pretty stupid. I just outed myself to someone who's not interested in me at all."

"What makes you say that?" Elaine asked.

"Kat grabbed the drinks and went out there and she hasn't come back, so I'm pretty sure we've just become bitter enemies or something and we'll have to incorporate that somehow into the pole routine that we have to duet for."

Elaine shrugged. "Well, it's not for me to say what Kat chooses to tell you, but I wouldn't give up quite yet. Kat doesn't talk much when she's caught by surprise, that's all." Elaine winked at Adora and stepped back out front, waving at Adora to come rejoin them.

When she got back out front, everyone was still chatting amiably about the show, but Kat was nowhere that she could see.

"Yeah," Adora said to herself. "Surprised her, that's all I did."

"You left your own party, hon," Elaine said. "Lonnie could have waited until later to collect on the bets, but at least you know now."

"Yeah, well, it would be fine, except as my calendar has so helpfully reminded me, we agreed weeks ago that she'd come over to practice the routine today. It was going to be awkward already, and now it's going to be extra awkward."

"Only if you don't talk to each other," Elaine said.

"And she just texted to say she's here," Kat said. "Goodbye, Elaine." Closing the video chat, she went to the door to let Adora in.

"I brought bagels," Adora said, holding up a bag. "I didn't know what kind you liked, so I tried to to get a variety."

Kat waved her in, indicated what counter to put the bagels on, and proceeded to give her the grand tour. "Kitchen's in that corner, bathroom's in this corner, bedroom is in that corner, and the pole is over here."

"Looks sturdy," Adora said. "I'm super jealous that you have a ground floor apartment, so you don't have to worry about the neighbors."

"Eh, the ones above me are practicing to be a thrash metal band," Kat said, "so they usually can't hear me if I accidentally kick the ceiling."

After dropping the bagels off, Adora took a steadying breath. Kat braced herself for whatever Adora had rehearsed a thousand times to say to her.

"I'm sorry," Adora said. "I didn't mean to make things awkward. If you're not interested in women, that's okay. I didn't want to ask you in front of anyone else, and I'm sorry there was a betting pool about it."

"You're dense sometimes, you know that?" Kat replied. "Why do you think there was a betting pool in the first place?"

Before Adora could reply, the sound of something clearly death metal inspired began playing from the upstairs apartment. Kat began to do her stretches, silent thanks given that while the upstairs apartment was pretty *terrible* at music, they were always extremely *punctual* about rehearsal.

What was she supposed to do, now that she knew that Adora was actually someone compatible? Kat had never really had someone interested in her like that. She'd gotten plenty of kicks out of flirting with the obviously straight girls in her hometown. Her mother had been too busy with trying to climb the career ladder to really talk with her about anything, other than her okay grades and "barely-restrained tendency toward delinquency," as the school counselor had put it. She thought she'd had Adora figured

out. She was a lot more fun to play with than the others were, since she actually played back. But Kat had figured Adora's red-faced behavior at the show had been Kat finally getting her too embarrassed to keep playing.

"What are you thinking about?" Adora asked, having gotten close enough to be heard over the metalheads.

"The routine," Kat replied. "It's not sensual enough."

"I agree," Adora said. "You're way better at that than I am. Can you teach me?"

"If I knew how," Kat said. "You've spent plenty of time staring at me, how do you think I do it?"

"If I knew that, I wouldn't be asking," Adora replied, smiling. "Guess you'll have to show me."

Kat turned away from Adora quickly to size up the pole. That challenge in Adora's voice had been what had always drawn her in to playing more, to trying to one-up Adora. Did she even know that was how she came across to Kat?

"Do you even know when you're flirting with someone?" Kat said, turning back to Adora.

"What?" Adora said, taken aback by the question.

"Ugh, look," Kat said, running a hand through her hair, "the jerks I have to deal with at work have a bigger clue than you do, and they're completely skeevy and obvious about it."

"Hey," Adora said, frowning. "I'm… not good at it, okay? I'm more used to having people laugh in my face about how far out of my league they are. Until last night, I assumed you were straight, because all the fun girls turn out to be straight. You're the first person that's flirted back."

The lightbulb turned on in Kat's brain, and she nearly facepalmed right there.

"I've got an idea about the routine," Kat said. "Adora, take your shirt off."

"What?"

"And if you've got shorts you're comfortable performing in, put those on."

"*What*?"

"Pretty sure you came prepared, so I'll bet you've got a sports bra on under your shirt," Kat said, pointing at Adora's chest. "Bike shorts, boy shorts, whatever you're comfortable with," she said, pointing at Adora's hips. "Show me just how much of a jock you can look like. I'll be right back."

Kat closed her bedroom door behind her and grabbed the orange two-piece that had been the original base for her fox costume. She'd assumed Adora had polished that "clueless jock" persona from long use and finding that it had worked with the women around her. If she really was just earnest and clueless, then Kat could work with that. She'd trained Kyle, she could do the same for Adora.

Stepping back outside in the two piece, her plan nearly fell off the rails in favor of dragging Adora to her bed and making sure neither of them left until they were exhausted. She'd been expecting a department store sports bra and some off the rack basketball shorts. Instead, Adora had a matching set of white and gold tank top and shorts that followed her lines like they had been tailored to her. In this outfit, it was impossible not to notice that Adora was ripped. How had she missed that all this time?

"Where have you been hiding all of that?" Kat said, gesturing at the obvious muscle now on display.

"You don't like it?" Adora said, trying to make herself smaller, less of the Amazonian goddess that she was and back into something more like the Adora Kat recognized. Kat blinked as another piece of the puzzle finally fell into place.

"It's perfect," Kat said firmly. "And our routine should show that off as much as possible. Remember how you said you wanted to rescue me last night?"

"Yeah," Adora said, turning red with embarrassment at the memory.

"Now's your chance," Kat said, turning away from Adora and heading to the pole, doing the fox walk that Elaine has told her emphasized her legs. It was *so* much easier to do now that she wasn't trying to balance in the damn heels. Kat dipped herself onto the pole, coiling around it in a slow spin and gave Adora a wink and a come-hither. For a moment, she worried she'd laid it on too thick, given the blush that was still on Adora's face, but then Adora got the determined look on her face she had when she was approaching a difficult spin, and Kat knew she had her.

Right at the end of her approach, Adora flexed her biceps and drew an imaginary arrow onto her imaginary bow, the mighty huntress come to rescue the damsel in distress. "Oh, shit," Kat said quietly, before her grip slipped on the pole and she crashed.

"Are you okay?" Adora said, dropping to her knees and looking around for something.

"I'm fine. Grip slipped," Kat said, very pointedly ignoring the picture in her head of Adora on her knees, hands on Kat's legs, holding Kat in place with her strength while teasing Kat her with her mouth. Kat stood back up again, putting her at exactly the height difference her fantasizing brain had imagined. Thankfully, Adora stood up as well, preventing her from acting rashly for the second time in as many opportunities.

"Ms. Fizz's poles are taller than this one," Adora said, studying it, "but what if I climbed up here and did this?" Adora pulled herself up near the top, hooked her thighs and legs, and then started a spin, allowing her to lean out as if she were looking far off into the distance from the top of the trees. "You can probably do the grind routine you were doing with Elaine last night underneath me."

Adora had been paying attention last night, then, Kat thought, even if she was getting super em—wait—what if Adora was embarrassed about being super turned on about the whole thing? That seemed like an idea worth testing. Making sure she was in Adora's sight, Kat went through the motions of the dance she would do while Adora was spinning above her, inching her way closer with every move until she was just out of Adora's reach, as best she could tell. Adora watched her for a little bit at the beginning, but after wobbling in her spin, Adora moved her gaze so that she seemed to be intently studying the patterns of something in the distance. Emboldened by Adora's response, Kat moved to the next phase of the plan.

"Then you come down gracefully," Kat said when Adora spun herself down, "and we do a little chase ourselves." Adora looked confused, but Kat beckoned her back to the pole, leaning toward Adora a little before coyly pulling away and stepping around to grind a little against her before moving away again. It took Adora a couple times to understand, but she was a fast learner, grabbing after Kat as she moved away, stalking her around the pole, until Adora reversed her direction with Kat and the two of them were standing face to face with each other. Kat reached up to run a gentle hand over Adora's cheek, which she repaid by holding it firmly in her hand. Kat did the same thing with the other hand, which Adora took hold of as well. Kat leaned in to give Adora a kiss, Adora mirroring her, but then Kat pulled away before their lips touched.

"You may have caught me, but you can't have me," Kat said, the unrepentant smile of the fox god on her face. "That's what the fox says to the hunter."

"I can't, huh?" Adora said, a grin of her own on her face. For a brief moment, Kat felt like she was falling down, before Adora's hands supported her and eased her the rest of the way to the floor. Adora straddled her at the waist, pinning Kat's hands above her. The swiftness at which she had been immobilized made Kat struggle, a rapidly expanding bloom of fear blotting out anything else she had been feeling up to that point. As easily as she had been pinned, Kat was free, Adora kneeling next to her as she sat upright, the terror receding from her veins as swiftly as it had appeared.

"I'm so sorry," Adora said. "I didn't know."

"*I* didn't know," Kat said. Adora's strength had, up to that point, been extremely sexy. And, now that her more rational brain functions were returning, it was definitely going back to that spot. Adora had certainly had all sorts of opportunities in this session to do something terrible, if she were going to.

"What were you going to do?" Kat asked.

"Tickle you," Adora said. "You've got all that exposed skin, and it's so tempting."

That was too funny for Kat not to react, and the absurdity of the situation and her primal relief at not being pinned any more meant she was howling at something that wasn't actually funny.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked with a tone that suggested she would be suspicious of "yes" as an answer. Kat nodded.

"How about we try that again, but this time, I won't freak out that you've got me right where I want you?"

"Shouldn't we rehearse the routine again?" Adora said, making Kat wonder if Adora genuinely missed the suggestion or was playing like she did because she didn't trust Kat's reasoning yet. "Yeah, okay, we can go one more time," Kat said, figuring that if Adora was feeling spooked, she wouldn't do the many different things that Kat's brain was helpfully feeding her as fun times to do

afterward. She managed to keep her focus all the way through to the end of the routine, where the fox would walk away from the hunter, still wild even after having stayed with the hunter a while.

"I think that'll be a great routine," Adora said. "Well need to practice it on Ms. Fizz's poles, but I like it."

"Yeah, me too." The lookout spin required a lot of strength for Adora, but when she held it, it made Kat want to get caught a lot faster than the routine said she should. "Bet you can't catch me again," she said, grinding up against Adora for just a touch before separating, just evading Adora's grab for her. This would be a fun chase that would end right where she wanted it to.

Adora reached out, and Kat shimmied away from her again, sticking her tongue out to tease Adora as she evaded her. Quicker than she had believed Adora could move, Adora grabbed one of Kat's arms and firmly pulled her toward her. Kat stumbled slightly into Adora's waiting embrace. Her arms were pinned to her sides, and Adora was smiling at her as she leaned in, and then they were kissing. Adora's enthusiasm helped hide that she clearly wasn't experienced at it, and Kat was looking forward to teaching her all the ways and things to kiss.

But first, she needed to get free. She worked against Adora's grip and tensed to spring away when Adora stopped squeezing her. Before she could get away, Adora had picked her up and was carrying her into her bedroom. No matter what Kat tried after that, Adora never lost control of her, whether in the quiet sections between the metalheads' rehearsal, or in the loud parts where the music would cover all the noise they were making as Adora exerted her control and made Kat her very satisfied, very well manipulated plaything.

"That is a very sensual performance," Ms. Fizz said approvingly after they finished for her. "And a very athletic one. Adora, I can see the work you're putting in trying to make it smooth and inviting. Kat, I think you can stand to work farther outside of your

comfort zone and trust your strength more. You make a good partnership." Ms. Fizz and the students applauded and Adora and Kat stepped away from the performance space.

It had gone well, thanks to the amount of time they had actually spent practicing being a partnership, and even occasionally working on their routine, at Kat's apartment. It was still very new for her to have someone who might be a girlfriend, and Adora worried that after that single day's worth of experiences, Kat wouldn't be interested in her any more and move on to finding someone else. Or once they were done being partners in pole class, as they were now, they would stop being partners outside of pole class.

Kat sat down next to her as Glimmer and Bo got ready to do their routine.

"Has he asked her out yet?" she said.

"I don't think he knows he's supposed to," Adora said. "Too much longer, though, and Glimmer will take things into her own hands. She always does when things are moving too slow for her liking. It's probably why she wouldn't shut up about your show."

"He's a himbo, I told you." Kat said. "Too clueless for his own good. If he's got any brains at all, he'll let her manage him as much as she wants to."

"Bo's not a himbo," Adora protested again. "He's shy about this kind of stuff. Not everyone is willing to basically strip on stage to catch the attention of a cute girl."

Kat laughed. "Have to cast a wide net when most of the audience isn't going to be your type."

Adora nodded. "Speaking of dating," she said as casually as she could muster, "are we?"

Kat looked at Adora briefly, but before she answered, Glimmer and Bo started their routine, and both of them focused on what was

going on in front of them. Adora was pleased to see Glimmer looked happy and confident while she spun and bounced next to Bo, who seemed equally at ease dancing and flexing next to her. Adora beamed and applauded when they finished. Glimmer gave a happy smile and went off with Bo's arm tucked in hers.

"I don't know," Kat said as the next pair was getting ready. "I've never been in this situation before. Elaine would probably say something like how I have self-sabotaging tendencies and want to push others away from myself because I don't fundamentally believe in my own worth, but the truth is that I've never really done much past fooling around with someone for a little bit."

That seemed like an oddly specific phrase to use to Adora. "What did you say Elaine's degree was in?" she asked.

"I don't know. Elaine never says," Kat replied.

"I get it, though," Adora replied, deciding not to get sidetracked. "I tend to charge ahead through obstacles when I want something, which works right up until I have to, y'know, be myself to get what I want, and then, well, if all I am is a dumb jock, then who actually wants to stick around with someone like that?"

"Excuse you, you are a *hot* dumb jock." Kat said, turning to her, a mock-serious look on her face.

"And you are a slippery little vixen," Adora said. Before the teasing could continue, the next pair began their routine.

"So, should we just keep this casual then, since we're both so concerned we're going to fuck it up?" Kat said after the routine had finished.

Casual was exactly the thing that Adora was concerned about. "Won't you get bored of me?" she said. "After we've done everything every which way you can think of, will that be everything?"

Kat ran a hand through her hair and laughed nervously. "I don't think that's going to happen. We probably shouldn't have introduced Elaine and Glimmer to each other if we wanted the possibility of staying apart. Or casual," she added.

"Oh. *Oh*," Adora said, as understanding reached her. She'd thought of Glimmer mostly as a gossip magnet, and Elaine would be a good source for gossip, but Glimmer had been the one doing a lot of the encouraging for Adora to keep pursuing Kat. If Elaine were the same way, then they'd *team up*, and Adora did not want to know what they could do if they were working together. "Yeah," Adora said faintly, "you're right. We… we need to get Elaine a partner. And encourage Glimmer to pursue Bo. If they're too busy chasing after their own people, they'll leave us alone long enough to decide what we want to do about each other."

"Deal," Kat said. "First planning session tonight, after class? We're going to need to feed them a steady diet of stories to keep them from interfering in our lives."

"Of course," Adora replied confidently. "And they're both the kind of people that will pry for details until they're confident it actually happened, so we may as well actually do the things so that we can talk about them from our experiences."

"I like the way you think, jock."

"I'll see you tonight, fox."

After the next routine, Glimmer bounced over and sat down next to them. "Hey, what's going on?" she said.

"Oh, nothing," Adora said, winking at Kat. Both of them gave Glimmer an evil grin, making her raise her eyebrows before they both pointedly turned back to watch the next routine.

Giving her a taste of her own medicine was going to be *fun*.

End Notes

The outfit that Adora has on for the apartment scene? I think it's something like what Claire Max modeled on Twitter here. Or, if Twitter makes you nervous, you can see the finished designs and their model at Castle Corsetry's Power Princess line. It was a very handy visual reference to come by while trying to envision this story.

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